

# Your First Home

A step-by-step guide to buying with confidence in the Triangle

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# A Note From Maria

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I moved to the U.S. when I was 12. Those first years were about learning English and figuring out a new country — nobody sat me down and explained how money, credit, or homeownership actually worked here. I picked it up piece by piece, later than I wish I had. I went on to become the first in my family to graduate college, and before I sold homes, I spent nine years teaching high school Spanish.

That gap in what nobody teaches you is why I wrote this guide. If you're doing well, working hard, and still feel like homeownership is something that happens to other people, this is for you. Buying a home isn't about being rich. It's about understanding a process that nobody taught you and having someone in your corner who will explain it in plain language — in English or en español.

I'm also an investor myself, buying and holding property in the Triangle since 2015, so I'm not just walking you through a transaction. I'm walking you through the first step of building something that outlasts a paycheck.

— *Maria*

# Money Myths That Keep Good Earners Renting

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These are the four things I hear most often from people who are more than ready to buy and don't know it yet.

## **“I need 20% down.”**

Most first-time buyers put down far less. Conventional loans can go as low as 3%, FHA loans as low as 3.5%, and some programs go lower still. On a \$350,000 home, 3% down is \$10,500 — not \$70,000.

## **“My credit isn't good enough.”**

Plenty of loan programs work with scores in the 580–620 range. The number that actually matters is the one a lender pulls for you, not the guess you're carrying around in your head.

## **“Renting is safer than buying.”**

Rent is money spent with nothing built. A mortgage payment builds equity every month, and in most cases a fixed mortgage payment is more predictable than a rent that goes up every renewal.

## **“I have to wait until I have more saved.”**

Waiting often means waiting for prices and rates to move against you instead. The better question isn't “do I have enough saved” — it's “do I qualify right now,” which takes one conversation with a lender to answer.

# What It Actually Costs

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Every deal is different, but here's a realistic starting point for a \$350,000 home so the numbers stop being abstract.

| Item                    | Typical range    | On a \$350,000 home                       |
|-------------------------|------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Down payment (3%–5%)    | 3%–5% of price   | \$10,500 – \$17,500                       |
| Closing costs           | 2%–5% of price   | \$7,000 – \$17,500                        |
| Due diligence fee       | 0.5%–1% of price | \$1,750 – \$3,500 (NOT refundable)        |
| Earnest money           | 1%–2% of price   | \$3,500 – \$7,000 (refundable, see below) |
| Home inspection         | Flat fee         | \$350 – \$600                             |
| Monthly payment (PITI)* | Varies with rate | Principal, interest, taxes & insurance    |

*\*PITI = principal, interest, taxes, and insurance — the four pieces of a monthly mortgage payment. A lender can give you an exact number in about 15 minutes once they see your income and credit.*

One thing that trips up a lot of first-time buyers in North Carolina: the due diligence fee and earnest money are not the same thing. The due diligence fee goes straight to the seller and is never refundable, no matter why you walk away. Earnest money, on the other hand, is fully refunded to you if you terminate during the due diligence period, for any reason. Knowing that difference upfront changes how much risk you're actually taking on.

Down payment assistance and first-generation buyer programs can lower these numbers further. Ask me which ones you may qualify for — it's one of the first things I check.

# Your Step-by-Step Path to Closing

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## 1. Get pre-approved

A lender reviews your income, debt, and credit and tells you exactly what you can borrow. This takes one conversation and costs nothing. Nothing else on this list happens until this step is done.

## 2. Define what you actually want

Neighborhoods, must-haves versus nice-to-haves, commute, schools if relevant. I build a real search around your life, not a generic listing feed.

## 3. Tour homes

I take you to see the ones that fit. I'll tell you honestly what I see — good bones, real problems, resale considerations — the way I'd tell a friend.

## 4. Write the offer

I build the offer around the numbers and the competition in that specific market, then negotiate on your behalf.

## 5. Home inspection (during due diligence)

A licensed inspector checks the property top to bottom. I use this to renegotiate repairs or price if something significant turns up — or to walk away and get your earnest money back, no questions asked, as long as you're still inside the due diligence period.

## 6. Appraisal & final loan approval

The lender confirms the home is worth what you're paying and finalizes your loan.

## 7. Closing

You sign the paperwork, get the keys, and the home is yours. Most buyers are shocked at how short this appointment actually is.

# Building Your Foundation: Credit & Savings

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## Good debt vs. bad debt

Good debt builds something — a mortgage, a business loan, a degree that raised your income. Bad debt disappears the moment you spend it — credit cards carrying a balance, buy-now-pay-later on things that lose value. Lenders read your debt the same way: what does this debt-to-income ratio say about you, not just what do you owe.

## Three moves that actually move your credit score

- Pay every bill on time, every time — this is the single biggest factor in your score.
- Keep credit card balances under 30% of your limit, ideally under 10%.
- Don't close old credit cards, even ones you don't use — length of credit history matters.

## Building your down payment fund

- Open a separate savings account just for this — out of sight keeps it out of temptation.
- Automate a transfer the day you get paid, before you see the number in checking.
- Any bonus, tax refund, or gift goes straight into the fund, no exceptions.

# Key Terms, in English and Español

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Real estate has its own language. Here are the terms you'll hear most, in both languages, so nothing gets lost along the way.

| English       | Español                 | What it means                                             |
|---------------|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Pre-approval  | Preaprobación           | A lender's written estimate of what you can borrow.       |
| Down payment  | Pago inicial / enganche | The upfront cash you put toward the purchase.             |
| Closing costs | Costos de cierre        | Fees paid at closing beyond the down payment.             |
| Escrow        | Custodia / plica        | A neutral account holding funds until conditions are met. |
| Appraisal     | Avalúo                  | A licensed estimate of the home's market value.           |
| Equity        | Plusvalía / capital     | The portion of the home's value you actually own.         |
| Earnest money | Depósito de buena fe    | A deposit showing you're serious about the offer.         |

# Let's Take the Next Step

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I'm a bilingual, Keller Williams Realty Cary agent serving the Triangle, and I've been a real estate investor myself since 2015. I built this guide because I believe the biggest thing standing between good earners and their first home is information, not money.

## Here's what happens when you're ready:

- We hop on a quick call or grab a coffee — no pressure, just questions answered.
- I connect you with a lender I trust so you know your real numbers within days.
- I build your search around your actual life and we start touring homes that fit.

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